

Westhampton, MA Finance Committee Meeting Minutes

February 22, 2023

Meeting commenced at 7:02pm in person at town hall

Jacob Antosz, Jeremy R. Durrin, Stephen Holt (absent), Marilyn Witherell, Tad Weiss, Scott Stanton (taking notes), Barbara Pellisier(via Zoom)
Also in attendance Joe Boudreau and Doug Finn

Meeting minutes from last meeting accepted - **6-0-0**

Reviewed first three pages of town expense report, Scott Stanton brought up a few that show over budget and they were explained to be a part of special budgets that don't properly fit into regular budgets and/or are revenues instead of expenses.

Review of FY24 Budget Line Items -

- Accounting Officer expenses
 - Very little change
 - Only changes explained by regular software expense increases, nothing we can do about these
- Tax collector expenses
 - Very little change
 - Only changes explained by regular software expense increases, nothing we can do about these
- Police expenses
 - Very little change, small decrease overall
 - Main differences related to Police Reform mandated by the state and a change in the cell phone services used for emergency reporting
- Fire department expenses
 - Barbara asked about the line of safety gear as to whether this is a one time expense or a rolling, regular expense. Jake explained that you have to keep buying safety equipment so that you always have enough for OSHA standards.
 - Level funded
 - Will have to ask about the purchase of foam used on vehicle fires when chief comes to explain
- Emergency Medical Services
 - Level funded
- Ambulance service
 - 3 year contract renewed with another 3 year contract for the same services via Easthampton
 - Still can be considered a bargain even considering the price increase for FY24

- Contract increases in steps each year an additional \$5,000 over the \$10,000 increase that came from the contract renewal initially
- Tree Warden expenses
 - Still waiting on a proposed budget from Tom Jenkins
 - He has been in contact with Eversource for taking some trees down and then he will be able to figure out a job to bid out based on remaining trees after Eversource is finished.
 - Doug double checking that Tom knows the date of his presentation to us
- Animal Control Officers expenses
 - Kelly Wainscott has been appointed
 - Level funded
 - Expects it to get spent in the FY
- Veterans Expense
 - Level funded
 - Adjusted FY2023 down because of a lack of spending in previous years
 - Expense based on how many veterans take the aid
 - We are currently down to 1 veteran in town using the services
 - Town applies to get reimbursed 75% by the state and that reimbursement goes into the general fund in the following year
 - Amount changes frequently based on the amount of veterans in town
- Memorial day
 - Level funded
 - For speakers on the day as a thank you and travel reimbursement
- Hampshire County Retirement
 - This is the town's payment into the county retirement fund
 - Required number, no changes possible
 - We are allowed to make one payment or two payments over the year and we typically go with the one time payment to save ~\$4,000 at \$251,758 vs \$255,957 for the bi-annual payments
 - Recommending that we change the budget number for FY24 so that it accurately depicts our plan for the one time payment
- Unemployment
 - Unemployment is 1% of the gross wages for the year
 - Budget number is this rounded up to the nearest 10
 - We are required to keep this in an account in case it needs to be spent which explains why there is such a large difference between budget and actual
- Group Health Insurance
 - Regularly calculated expense that cannot be changed
- Medicare
 - Very little change
 - Calculated expense based on 1.45% of gross wages including COLA
- OPEB Trust
 - Other Post Employment Benefits

There is a concern about the treasurer's task book from September 2022. The cash book amount and the accounting system at the bank has a difference of ~\$500. Joe will be working on the reason for this discrepancy.

Vote to adjourn meeting at 8:35 passed **6-0-0**